

My mom was more responsible, but her upbringing had also been less than stable. Her father, Harvey, was an alcoholic too, and her parents split up when she was young. Her dad fixed vending machines, sold insurance, and worked for the telephone company. At the telephone company, he stole phones and sold them on the side, which got him fired. He then drove a cab in Manhattan and fell way into debt. Harvey took out so many loans that my mom eventually had to tell the bank not to issue him any more. She suspected her father was in over his head with gambling.

My mom guessed that if my grandmother been born some decades later, she would have been a successful businesswoman. But in the 1950s, Lee's independence made her stick out in a negative way. (Harvey was interested in history, which working-class people didn't go to school for because it was seen as a waste of money.) Their low stations in life limited both of them. Their families didn't invest in their futures. Lending always came with emotional strings and judgments attached. This is why, my mom contends, she spent so much money on me and my sister.

When she was growing up, my mom worked in a drugstore in Manhattan selling makeup. After graduating from Brooklyn College, she went to law school in Florida at Nova Southeastern University while she also worked three jobs and was on food stamps. Her furniture was comprised of bricks with wooden slats. She graduated in 1980, began working in criminal law, and started paying the loans back the next year. It took her twelve years to pay them off, but she did it.

My memories of my mom in the 1990s are of her on "roller skates." It's something I used to say when I was a kid: "My mom wears roller skates to work," meaning she was always moving. I'd go to work with her, and she'd rush from one courtroom to another or from one end of her office to another. She never sat down. She wore this terrible black and yellow blazer that I called "the bumblebee" because she just looked like a blur—a flying, buzzing bee skipping from one flower to the next. She worked a lot, and even though she was always working, we never seemed to have any money to show for it.

For my whole life, my mom has been the breadwinner of our family. She still works as a divorce and child custody attorney, but recently she wasn't making enough at her private practice to continue using it as her only revenue stream, so